

Muscles and movement

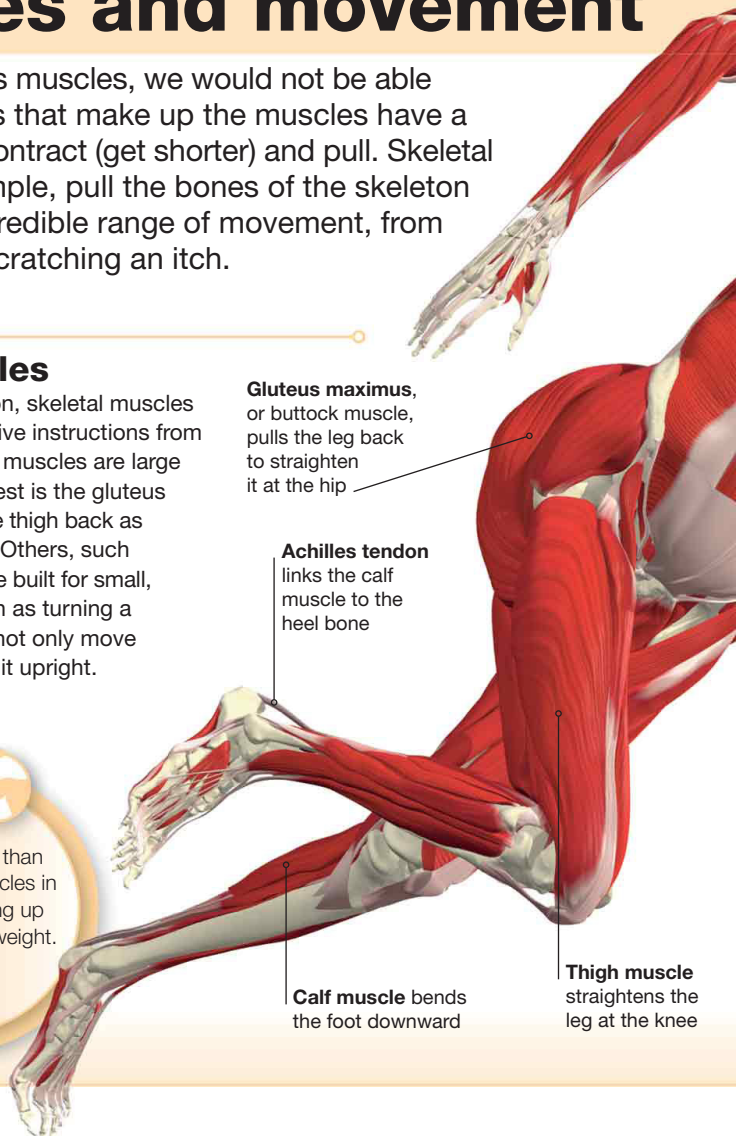
Without the body's muscles, we would not be able to move. The cells that make up the muscles have a unique ability to contract (get shorter) and pull. Skeletal muscles, for example, pull the bones of the skeleton to produce an incredible range of movement, from kicking a ball to scratching an itch.

Skeletal muscles

Layered over the skeleton, skeletal muscles contract when they receive instructions from the brain. Some skeletal muscles are large and powerful—the bulkiest is the gluteus maximus, which pulls the thigh back as we walk, run, and jump. Others, such as the finger muscles, are built for small, precise movements such as turning a page. Skeletal muscles not only move the body, they also hold it upright.



There are more than 640 skeletal muscles in the body, making up nearly half of its weight.



Gluteus maximus, or buttock muscle, pulls the leg back to straighten it at the hip

Achilles tendon links the calf muscle to the heel bone

Calf muscle bends the foot downward

Thigh muscle straightens the leg at the knee